Water Recreation Safety Guide

Safety essentials for kayaking, paddleboarding, boating, and water recreation in Pierce County

Pierce County's waterways range from the frigid open waters of Puget Sound to glacial-fed rivers, alpine lakes, and lowland reservoirs. The water here is beautiful — and dangerously cold year-round. Our SAR unit supports water-related emergencies, and cold water is the #1 factor in every incident.

CRITICAL: COLD WATER KILLS

Puget Sound water temperature rarely exceeds 55°F, even in summer. Glacial-fed rivers and mountain lakes can be 40-50°F. At these temperatures, cold water shock occurs within the first 60 seconds — causing involuntary gasping, hyperventilation, and panic. You can lose the ability to swim in as little as 10 minutes. ALWAYS WEAR A LIFE JACKET.

Pierce County Waterways

Puget Sound / Commencement Bay

Open salt water with tidal currents, ferry traffic, cargo ships, and wind chop. Water temps 47-55°F year-round. Experienced paddlers only for routes from Steilacoom, Ruston, and Owen Beach. Watch for ferries — they cannot stop or maneuver to avoid you. Tidal current charts are essential.

Rivers: Puyallup, Carbon, Nisqually, White

Glacial-fed rivers that are COLD, silty, and can rise rapidly during warm afternoons as snowmelt increases. Log jams are deadly — water flows under them but you don't. Never float unfamiliar river sections without scouting. The Puyallup River through Orting and Sumner has swift current and limited access points.

SAR PRO TIP

River levels in Pierce County can change dramatically in a single day. A calm morning float can become a dangerous afternoon torrent as glacial melt peaks. Check USGS river gauges (waterdata.usgs.gov) before and during your trip. If the level is rising, get off the water.

Lakes: Spanaway, American, Kapowsin, Tanwax

Lowland lakes offer the most accessible paddling in Pierce County. Warmer water (60-70°F in summer), protected from wind, and close to services. Great for beginners and families. Still carry a life jacket — even calm lakes claim lives every year.

Alpine Lakes: Mowich, Eunice, others

Mountain lakes above 4,000 ft are spectacularly beautiful and extremely cold (40-55°F even in August). Remote, with no rescue services nearby. A capsize here is a life-threatening emergency. Only for experienced, well-prepared paddlers.

Washington State Water Safety Laws

- ☐ Life jackets: ALL vessels (kayaks, canoes, SUPs, boats) must carry one USCG-approved PFD per person. Children 12 and under must WEAR theirs.
- ☐ SUPs: Stand-up paddleboards are legally vessels. PFD required on board. Leash strongly recommended.
- ☐ Sound signal: Whistle or horn required on all vessels for signaling in fog or emergencies.
- ☐ Navigation lights: Required from sunset to sunrise and in restricted visibility.
- ☐ Boater education: Required for operators born after Jan 1, 1955 (exceptions for out-of-state visitors under 60 days).
- ☐ Alcohol: BUI (boating under the influence) carries the same penalties as DUI.

Water Recreation Safety

Before You Launch

- ☐ Check weather forecast AND wind forecast. Wind on open water creates dangerous conditions fast.
- ☐ File a float plan: where you're launching, your route, expected return time.
- ☐ Dress for the water temperature, not the air temperature. Wetsuit or drysuit in cold water.
- ☐ Wear your PFD. Don't just carry it. 85% of drowning victims were not wearing a life jacket.
- ☐ Bring a whistle, signaling mirror, and waterproof phone case.
- ☐ Tell someone your plan and check in when you return.

Paddleboard & Kayak Specific

Wear a leash (SUP) or practice wet exits (kayak) before going out. Carry a paddle float for self-rescue. In cold water, you may only have 10-15 minutes of useful muscle function after immersion. Stay close to shore until you're confident in your skills and self-rescue ability. Avoid offshore winds — they push you away from shore and are very hard to paddle against.

If You Capsize in Cold Water

1) Don't panic. Control your breathing (cold shock causes gasping).
2) Get as much of your body out of the water as possible (climb on hull, debris).
3) If you can't get out, assume the HELP position: knees to chest, arms crossed.
4) Don't try to swim unless shore is very close. Swimming accelerates heat loss.
5) Signal for help: whistle, bright clothing, waving.

SAR PRO TIP

The '1-10-1 rule' for cold water: You have 1 minute to get your breathing under control (cold shock), 10 minutes of meaningful movement (before muscles fail), and potentially 1 hour of consciousness. This timeline shrinks in colder water. That first minute — controlling your breathing — is the most critical. Practice it mentally before you paddle.

Emergency Preparedness

Water emergencies escalate fast. Cell service is unreliable on the water. Consider a waterproof VHF radio (channel 16 for emergencies) for Puget Sound paddling, and satellite communicator for remote rivers and lakes.

SATELLITE 911 TEXTING

T-Mobile offers satellite 911 texting — FREE for all carriers (emergency 911 only). Full satellite messaging is $10/mo. Keep your phone in a waterproof case. Sign up at t-mobile.com/coverage/satellite-phone-service/911-texting-signup